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1928, J.P. Saunders' Murder

It was the assassination of a police officer by Bhagat Singh and his comrades that, in the end, sent him to the gallows. This was in turn a consequence of the killing by the Lahore police of Lala Lajpat Rai, who had decided to mobilize support against the Simon Commission. But well before the arrival of the Simon Commission in Lahore on 30 October 1928, Indian organizations, from the Congress Party, the Naujawan Bharat Sabha, the Students' Union and the Hindustani Sewa Daal had decided to boycott this delegation. Some 5,000 protesters had gathered at the Lahore Railway Station to oppose the seven-man commission spearheaded by Sir John Allsebrook Simon. When the Simon Commission arrived in Lahore on 30 October 1928, it was greeted by an angry procession chanting, '*Hindustani hain hum, Hindustan hamara / Mur Jao Simon jahan hai desh tumhara*' ('Hindustani we are, Hindustan is ours/ Go and die Simon, in that country which is yours'). The authorities were all too aware of the mood on the street. This is why as Kuldip Nayar observes, the police superintendent of Lahore, J.A. Scott, ordered a lathi charge. When Lala Lajpat Rai enjoined them to hold on to their positions as satyagrahis, (true warriors) many turned back upon hearing his exhortations. It was then that 'Scott spotted Lajpat Rai from a distance and went for him' and 'the policeman used his baton to beat the Indian leader mercilessly and did not stop even when blood began spurting from Lajpat Rai's chest'. In fact, 'Scott did not stop till Lalaji fell down' and 'it looked as if Scott was releasing his pent-up anger against all those who defied the British'. If this was so, then it was all too reminiscent of how 'only nine years earlier, General R.E.H. Dyer, an Irishman born in Shimla, had wreaked his vengeance upon the people at